Case study

Report

VITYARTHI PROJECT

Title	Digital literacy
Created by	Saurav Kumar
Registration no	25Bsa10125
Institution	Vellore institute of technology bhopal

Section A: Establishing the Context

1. The Illusion of Digital Competence

In the modern academic landscape, we often mistake "tool familiarity" for "digital understanding". Students today are highly comfortable with platforms like Canva, Miro, and Prezi. However, this comfort is often surface-level; we use drag-and-drop interfaces and AI-generated suggestions that reduce the need for actual technical critical thinking.

2. The Gap Between Usage and Awareness

- Digital literacy is not merely knowing how to operate a tool; it is about understanding the consequences of our digital actions.
- While a student may know how to apply a template in Canva, they may remain unaware of copyright issues or data privacy concerns.
- The convenience of modern tools often leads students to stop questioning the

- content they create, such as using inappropriate GIFs in formal settings or copying designs that violate originality standards.
- As the case study notes, we have become "consumers of digital convenience" rather than critical thinkers.

Section B: Digital Identity & Ethics

1. The Paradox of the "Public Profile"

In the current academic and professional climate, students are under immense pressure to curate a "digital brand" before they have even mastered their core disciplines. For a student like Arjun, platforms like LinkedIn, GitHub, and Kaggle are not just tools; they are the primary lenses through which the professional world views his potential.

However, a critical paradox emerges: these platforms are designed to showcase **outputs**, not the **process** of learning. When Arjun uploads code from a lab assignment to GitHub, the platform rewards the presence of the repository, but it cannot inherently verify if the code was written through deep struggle or simply copied to meet a deadline.

2. Visibility vs. Authenticity: The Performance Trap

Digital platforms often create a "veneer of competence". Because these interfaces prioritize aesthetics—such as a green contribution heat map on GitHub or a list of "endorsed" skills on LinkedIn—students often prioritize **visibility over actual skill acquisition**.

- **The Illusion of Credibility:** In the digital realm, everything appears equally credible when presented with high-quality visual design. A student who uses a professional headshot and buzzword-heavy bio may appear more "skilled" than a peer with deeper knowledge but a less curated profile.
- **The Normalization of Exaggeration:** Arjun’s decision to list skills he had only briefly explored wasn't necessarily a malicious act of dishonesty. Rather, it was a response to a competitive environment where he believed "everyone else was doing it". This creates an ethical "race to the bottom" where authenticity is sacrificed for a competitive edge.

- **3. The Concept of Digital Permanence**

One of the most overlooked risks for students is that the internet is a **permanent record**. Unlike a failed classroom mock-interview that is forgotten by the next semester, a poorly documented GitHub repo or an incorrect technical answer on Stack Overflow remains accessible for years.

- **Long-term Recruiter Perception:** A recruiter looking at Arjun’s profile five years from now might not see his "early attempts" as growth; they might see a history of "inconsistency" or "short-cuts".
- **The Accountability Tension:** This raises a difficult ethical question: Should students be held strictly accountable for their digital footprints from a time when they lacked professional awareness?. While learning requires the freedom to make mistakes, the digital world often treats those mistakes as permanent data points.

4. My Argument: The Ethical Imperative for Students

I argue that building a digital presence is a **double-edged sword**. While it democratizes opportunity by allowing anyone to showcase their work regardless of background, it also exposes students to "reputational risk" if they prioritize performance over truth.

To navigate this ethically, students must shift their mindset:

- **GitHub** should be a "lab notebook" of genuine progress, not just a gallery of finished (or copied) products.
- **LinkedIn** should reflect "current capabilities," with a clear distinction between a skill one is *learning* versus one they have *mastered*.
- **Authenticity** must become a strategic choice. In the long run, a recruiter will value a student who can explain every line of a simple code project over a student who cannot explain a complex project they "borrowed"

Section C: Collaboration & Accountability

1. The Efficiency Paradox

Arjun’s group assignment using Google Docs and Slides appeared efficient because the group did not need to meet physically. However, the polished final output masked a significant "learning gap".

2. Unequal Participation

- In digital collaboration, individual effort is often not immediately visible to faculty.
- In Arjun’s case, one student did most of the work while others made minor formatting changes or copied content from online sources.
- The system treated all contributions as equal, allowing some members to avoid accountability.
- The result was a high score, but limited understanding for several members. Digital

collaboration without accountability
produces strong outputs but weak learning.

Section D: Cyber Awareness and Responsibility

1. The Gap Between Knowledge and Behavior

The most striking element of Arjun's case is that he had prior knowledge of phishing attacks from his university sessions. This highlights a critical psychological gap: **academic awareness does not automatically translate into real-world caution**.

- **The Power of Context:** Cyber crimes like phishing succeed not because of a lack of technical education, but because they exploit human emotions like **urgency** and **aspiration**.
- **The Trap of Professionalism:** Arjun was deceived because the email used a professional-looking logo and a structured message that mimicked a legitimate corporate communication. This "trust in appearances" often overpowers the logical impulse to verify details.

2. Behavioral Triggers: Why We Click

Phishing attacks are successful because they are designed to bypass the "slow thinking" part of our brain. In Arjun's case, several factors contributed to his lapse in judgment:

- **Artificial Scarcity:** The email mentioned "limited slots," creating a fear of missing out (FOMO).
- **Temporal Pressure:** The 12-hour deadline for "verification" forced Arjun to act quickly. When we are rushed, we prioritize speed over verification.
- **Confirmation Bias:** Since Arjun was already actively applying for internships, his brain saw this scam as a "breakthrough" and ignored the warning signs, such as the slightly altered sender address.

3. Allocation of Responsibility: Individual vs. Systemic

A central debate in digital literacy is who should be held accountable when a student falls victim to a scam.

- **Individual Responsibility:** Users like Arjun are responsible for basic hygiene—checking email headers, avoiding suspicious links, and never sharing credentials. Cyber safety must be treated as a **continuous habit**, not a one-time lesson.
- **Platform & Institutional Responsibility:** However, it is also a **systemic failure**. Digital platforms are engineered to reward the very behaviors that attackers exploit: quick responses and high engagement. Institutions like VIT Bhopal have a responsibility to move beyond theoretical lectures and implement "simulated" environments where students can practice identifying threats in a safe space.
- **The "Negligence" Myth:** Viewing a victim's mistake as "negligence" ignores the sophisticated social engineering used by modern cybercriminals. True prevention requires a partnership where platforms build safer "defaults" (like multi-factor authentication) and users maintain a "healthy skepticism".

4. The Lasting Impact of Cyber Incidents

For Arjun, the aftermath was not just technical; it was emotional. He experienced anxiety regarding data misuse and a significant loss of trust in online opportunities.

- **Data Misuse:** Once sensitive information is submitted, the user loses control over their digital identity.
- **Erosion of Trust:** A single scam can make a student hesitant to pursue legitimate digital opportunities, effectively creating a "digital barrier" to their career growth.

Section E: Communication and Digital Etiquette

1. Informal Habits in Formal Spaces

Arjun’s email to his professor ("Hi sir, I need recommendations urgently. Send asap.") failed because it mirrored the casual tone of instant messaging.

- In formal contexts, an email is a "first point of contact" that reflects a student’s attitude, seriousness, and respect for the recipient.
- Habit often overrides awareness; students know the correct format but choose speed over presentation.

2. The Impact of Professionalism

- A well-structured email with a subject line and a polite closing provides context and shows respect.

- For Arjun, his unprofessional tone resulted in a distant, transactional response rather than a supportive one.

Section F: Personal Reflection

After analyzing this case, I have realized that my own digital habits are often dictated by speed.

- **Behavioral Change:** I plan to implement a "30-second pause" before clicking links in emails or submitting group work to ensure I am acting with awareness rather than just activity.
- **Final Insight:** Digital literacy is defined by the quality of our decisions, not the quantity of our tools.